Hordak the Horde Dad

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Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Hordak (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

Characters:
Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Adora, Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Imp (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Protective Hordak, villains trying to be better people, Confused Catra, needlessly terrified Bow, Hordak will retroactively adopt the entire Horde, Soft Hordak, Emotional Conversations, purposeful emotional growth, Adora looking for answers

Language:
English

Collections:
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Stats:
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Hordak the Horde Dad

by LillyLaroux (NinaWhite)

Summary

Or 5 times Hordak tried to look after someone else and 1 that someone looked after him.

After the dust had settled and reconstruction was well underway something started to become obvious. Something utterly unexpected and frankly bizarre. But the longer peace went on for, the more difficult it became to ignore.

Hordak, despite having no father figure to base his behaviour on, was paternal. Very paternal. Taking anyone that he had had even a passing responsibility for under his wing much to the growing bafflement of anyone that found themselves the target of his fatherly instincts.

Notes

Not sure what the ultimate rating on this will be, it may end up going up but I have no idea. Entrapta will be in it more as it goes on but most ships will be background ships. Tags will also be added to as more come up.

See the end of the work for more notes

What's in a Name?

“I NEED YOU TO HIDE ME FROM HORDAK!” Bow cried as he burst into the room. Catra blinked at him from her place on the giant pillow chair thing. The archer was clearly panicked, panting as if he’d ran half way across the palace and standing with his arms as wide open as the doors now were. Stealth never had been his strong suit but this was just ridiculous.

“Why would you need to hide from Hordak?” she asked, her tone slow and more than a little patronising. Hordak was at Brightmoon, part of Entrapta’s entourage from Dryl along with a few clones and a few Etherian’s that Catra had never seen before. Here to discuss reparations or something like that. He’d effectively been put on an indefinite community service sentence and had been strangely accepting of it. In fact he’d been bizarrely mellow about everything as far as Catra had seen, not that she’d gone out of her way to spend time with him. From a distance however, he’d seemed more interested in making lovey eyes at Entrapta than wreaking havoc.

“No time! Just hide!”

With an exasperated sigh, Catra pushed out of her oversized pillow and shoved Bow into the overly ornate wardrobe. A muffled thank you met her ears and she rolled her eyes. What was with these rebellion people and not knowing what stealth was? She wandered closer to her comfy spot, stopping to reach up into a spine popping stretch.

And just as she was on her tiptoes, arms reaching up and back bowed, Hordak stormed past her open door. Catra froze, the snarl on his face and the clenched fists far too reminiscent of when he'd been on the warpath in the Fright Zone.

Maybe Bow had the right idea after all.

The sound of Hordak's footsteps stopped as Catra relaxed back into her normal stance, then they began again but growing closer until he was back in her doorway.

"Catra," he said, his voice a low rumble of displeasure. The ingrained urge to stand to attention struck, stuffed down by sheer stubbornness. "Have you seen Bow? I need to speak with him."

"What did he do?" she asked, making sure her voice was a semi-disinterested drawl.

"What makes you think he's done anything?" Hordak demanded, his scowl intensifying as he narrowed his eyes at her.

"Are you kidding?" she teased with a little laugh before flopping back down into her pillow. She would be at ease around him. She wasn't his Force Captain anymore. She wasn't some scared cadet and he wasn't a warlord. He was just a princess's pet now. Like her. "You look like you just found out Shadow Weaver was skimming from the munitions fund."

He blinked at her twice, slowly.

"She wasn't, was she?"

"No, of course not," Catra said, waving away his concern. "It was the food budget."

A bitten off hiss erupted from Hordak's throat. He squeezed his eyes shut and took slow breath after slow breath, clearly counting as he did. Oh, she recognised that technique. When had he been spending time with Perfuma?

"That does not matter," he said with a forced calm, red eyes still closed. "I can do nothing about that and it is better that such things remain in the past."

"You're better at that than I am," she commented mildly.

"I've had good reason to practice. I doubt people have flashbacks when you get angry." At that, Catra cringed in sympathy.

"Point taken. So, what do you want Bow for?"

Hordak rolled his shoulders, an old sign of displeasure, and his ear dropped down and were pinned backward in a gesture that was eerily like her own body language.

"We need to have a discussion about the manner in which he believes it is reasonable to assist the clones in finding their own names." Well that was interesting.

"Oh this should be good," she replied with a smirk. "What did he actually do?" Hordak ground his teeth aggressively enough that it nearly made Catra shudder.

"You know of the clone that was referred to as Wrong Hordak?" She nodded as Hordak pushed down a low rumbling growl seemingly by sheer force of will. "They are currently in search of a new name and Bow suggested Kadroh as when they found him they thought he was me but they-"

"Got it backwards," Catra interrupted with a groan. "That's a bad joke even by Sea Hawk's standards."

"Joke or not, *Kadroh* has latched onto it. Which is his prerogative I suppose and he did make the case that it honours the origins of his freedom while also being something of his own. But I do not think that Bow fully understands the vulnerability of the clones. While they are fully mature of body, they do not have the breadth of experience that would be expected of an adult and by far the vast majority of them will be under ten years of age by the standards of Etheria."

Catra tilted her head, considering his words. He made sense and she could see why he'd be angry. Wrong Hordak- Kadroh now apparently, had been unnervingly child-like in a great many ways and she could see how that would be easy to take advantage of or accidentally influence. There was a fine line between respecting the knowledge and mature brain chemistry of the clones and being careful of their naivety.

"You really care about the other clones don't you?" Catra asked, curious about the whole situation. If he was capable of caring for them then he had been capable of caring for the cadets and she couldn't help but wonder. Hordak bared his teeth but didn't hiss. The expression soon fell away however, leaving him to shift uncomfortably.

"I confess, as the oldest of them and the only one with any extended experience of living outside of Prime's influence, I feel . . . responsible for them," he finished, somewhat unsure of himself if she was reading his ears right. She took a moment to take in how he was holding himself. Proud but self conscious, probably still working out how to stand on this new ground he had found himself on, which was something she could definitely relate to. Hordak had been many things, but a liar had never been one of them. If he said he was working on his temper, he meant it. If he said he felt responsible for the well being of the other clones, he meant it.

Without thinking, she slow blinked at him. A bolt of horror shot through her when she realised not only what she'd just done, not only that she had meant it, but that from the ear flick an the look of shock he'd known what it meant.

“Bow is in the wardrobe,” she told him.

The wardrobe door burst open and Bow ran flailing out and straight to the balcony with an extended panicked scream. He leapt over the edge, turning in the air and firing an arrow with a rope on it into the wall of the palace to abseil out of view.

Catra and Hordak stayed quiet, listening as the not quite scream got quieter the further away Bow got. They shared a confused glance, Catra shrugging at the over reaction.

“You see, that is precisely why I am trying so hard to resolve my issues with my temper,” Hordak said in a total deadpan that had Catra snorting out an uncontrolled laugh on her pillow.

Sometimes It's Just Nice To Hear

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora watched from a way down the coast. It was strange, even without the uniform she found it easy to recognise the Horde in action. There was an easy efficiency to them. Disciplined in a way that she'd seen other Etherian's weren't, even those with a military background. Despite herself and despite all she'd been through, the sight made her feel strangely at home. Part of her expected to see Shadow Weaver moving through the dozens of people that were working to rebuild the village.

It was good. She couldn't argue with that. Salineas was the Kingdom most devastated by the war outside of the Fright Zone. But it was so strange. The uniforms were gone, so were the banners, but this was still the Horde teaming though this village. Fixing what they had broken.

And at the hub of the activity was a sight that still had Adora uneasy. Hordak stood at a large table covered in papers and tokens, reviewing plans and directing people. It could have been a war table and he certainly looked like he was approaching this as seriously as a battle. People approaching him for their next step, easily seeking his authority the way they had in the Fright Zone.

It was unnerving. Clearly there were enough people left from the Horde desperate for some sort of guidance that he could have rebuilt it and kept trying to retake Etheria. The fact that he hadn't done anything about it yet had an odd feeling settling into her stomach.

Well, that would probably be a problem for future Adora, like everything else was. They had to at least give him a chance to do better this time. So she swallowed her discomfort and made her way to the hub of the construction.

Hordak had his back to her as she approached, a long dark blue coat with a high collar taking the place of the cape she was used to, his claw tapping on the plans as he spoke in an authoritative tone to Commander Cobalt-no. Not commander, not anymore. Just Cobalt.

"It's another two days before the crane arrives so we'll have to wait until then to move the frames, not ideal, but we can make sure the trenches are dug for the new energy supply cables in the meantime."

Adora cleared her throat, not sure if there was a protocol on this. Hordak looked over his shoulder to her, his eyes glowing red again, though it was less threatening in the full light of day.

"Adora? I wasn't expecting you," he said mildly. "Do you need something?"

"Just a conversation," she replied, trying not to give in to the instinct to shrink under his attention.

"I'll leave you to it," Cobalt said before doing the best at slinking off that someone his size could manage.

Hordak turned to face her as she shifted her weight from foot to foot, half expecting a formal dressing down. It was strange how he could look so much like his old self and yet nothing like it at all at the same time. The red glow, the dark blue hair and the black smudges around his eyes. Back into his dark clothing, though the Horde symbol was nowhere in sight and instead there was a broach on the lapel of his coat, gleaming purple set of gears, the emblem of Dryl.

"Sooooo," she began, suddenly unsure that even coming here was a good idea. "You're running things here?"

Hordak stared at her, a deep breath making his shoulders rise and fall.

“Not intentionally,” he replied with an annoyed curl of his lip. “But everyone kept coming to me for work assignments, despite repeated redirection, so it simply became the most efficient way of working here. It was also the easiest way to ensure people were taking adequate breaks and eating correctly. Almost everyone here is apparently terrible at that.”

“Oh, okay. I- I mean that makes total sense. I can see how that happened and-”

“Adora,” he interrupted, clearly impatient. With another deep breath he pinched the short bridge of his nose and visibly took hold of his temper. “There is a lot of work to be done here so I would appreciate it if you could resist your urge to nervously ramble and get to the point.”

“Right. Yes, sorry. It’s just, erm.” She swallowed as she locked eyes with him, or at least she thought she did, it was hard to tell when his glowed like that. “Why did you give me to Shadow Weaver?” she finally managed to blurt out. “I saw the memory of you finding me when I burnt out Prime and I could tell that you wanted to keep me but you didn’t and I just, I just wanted to know why.”

His ears drooped and eyebrows raised. Surprise maybe, or concern. She had a harder time reading him than she did Kadroh. There always seemed to be something held back about him, even when he was being emotive.

“Come with me,” he eventually said before beginning to walk back the way she had come. It didn’t take them long to be out of the village turned building site and soon they were out of ear shot and up on the slight rise that Adora had been watching from earlier.

He considered her for a moment once they came to a stop, then turned to look out over Horde at work.

“I’m not sure what answers you want from me,” he began. “Despite not being in the hivemind I was still very much under Prime’s thumb. The only thing I allowed myself to care about was returning to Prime’s light with a big enough trophy to show that I was worthy of assuming my old position. A position he’d completely done away with, but I had no way of knowing that.”

Adora looked away, wrapping her arms around herself. A pang of disappointment settled heavy in her gut and she couldn’t quite place why. She remembered the powerful protective urge that Hordak had felt looking at her, the sheer strength of that urge, to keep her, to raise her. She had been sure it had meant something, but apparently not.

“Even with all of that, I still wanted to keep you. I didn’t understand the urge, I didn’t know what I would do with you, but I wanted you safe and close. But I had no idea how to raise a child. We had cadets and I knew that they were well fed and trained. All things have a place within the Horde.”

She looked up to him, heart in her mouth. But he wasn’t looking at her, he was looking out over the people working below.

“I’d never been a child, nor had I ever had a hand in raising one. Attempting to do so would take up much of my time and distract from my ultimate goal. On top of that, if I had not been entirely purified of parental instinct by the light of Prime I was sure such instincts would be at odds with your needs given our obviously differing species.”

“So you gave me to Shadow Weaver,” she said, trying not to sound like she was accusing him of something. He looked back to her, ears back and flat against his head with a frown on his face.

“It seemed like the logical thing to do at the time. You looked like many of the Etherian children I had seen and I had no reason to doubt that your needs would be similar. Shadow Weaver worked closely with the cadets and had experience with a great many children. I viewed her as my expert in such matters. Apparently

that was something of a misconception," he finished with a snarl. Adora couldn't hold back in an unimpressed snort.

"That's an understatement," she grumbled. Shadow Weaver was, well, complicated. She didn't doubt that the woman had loved her and there was no one else that Adora could even begin to look at as a mother figure, but that didn't excuse the hell that she'd put her and Catra through as they grew up.

Hordak reached out, hesitant and giving her plenty of time to pull away before his clawed hand settled on her shoulder. She looked up to him with eyes wide, His hand was huge, covering her whole shoulder, but his grip was gentle.

"If I had known what Shadow Weaver was doing to you and Catra I would have stepped in. Even as ignorant as I was about Etherian child development, and believing that it is through suffering that we become pure, I would not have allowed it to continue.

"I am sorry that she hurt you. If I had not been a, how did Catra put it? A shut in that never left my lab? I would have seen what she was doing. My ignorance is no excuse for my inaction. Ultimately all of the children of the Horde were my responsibility and I failed them. I failed you."

His hand fell away from her shoulder and he looked back towards the people working below as Adora felt her eyes sting.

"I cannot say that things would have been much better had I stepped in given how I saw things at that time, but at very least the cruelty would have been less personal-"

Adora threw herself at him, wrapping her arms around his middle and burying her face into his chest. He had always seemed huge to her and now was no different. She barely came up to his shoulder. He froze under her hold, his whole body stiff and the wool of his coat rough against her cheek. Just as she was beginning to worry she'd massively overstepped and made things supper awkward, Hordak relaxed. His arms came up to lightly rest

on across her as if he wasn't entirely sure how to do this. Which, that just couldn't be right, she'd seen him and Entrapta, they barely put each other down unless they were working and even then more often than not they were pressed up against each other, Entrapta was sitting on him or had a lock of hair tangled around part of him. Maybe he was just unsure of how to touch her.

"I know that it's not really my place to say this," he said as a soft purr began to rumble from his chest. "But I am proud of you. Of all that you've done, of who you have grown to be and of the happiness you have found."

She held on tightly for a moment, eyes squeezed shut against threatening tears as she tried to imagine a life without Shadow Weaver and with Hordak instead only to find her heart aching. He was right. It wouldn't have been a better life, not really. There would have been less cruelty, less pain. But there also would have been less affection as fleeting and as conditional as it had been.

Adora pulled away from him, trying to be subtle about wiping her eyes and he gave her shoulder one last awkward pat before locking his arms behind his back again.

"You've been going to Perfuma's therapy sessions, haven't you?" she teased. Hordak's ears tinged red and stuck out to the side.

"Er- I find Princess Perfuma to be very wise about such matters," he stuttered out. "Also I've been reading about Etherian child development in an effort to understand what happened with Catra being, er-"

"Catra," Adora finished for him, taking mercy. "Good luck with that. Speaking of other halves, I thought Entrapta would be here."

"She's working on a frequency dampener for our excursion to Beast Island," he replied with a fond smile. "Though I believe she may have forgotten it was meant to be a punishment. She keeps referring to it as our holiday." Adora let out a snort.

“Yeah, that sounds like Entrapta.” With a smile she tugged a little on Hordak’s sleeve and took a bouncing few steps down the hill. “Anyway, I overheard that you needed something super heavy lifting. Let me help.”

“It would be an honour to work alongside you,” he replied with a small fond smile.

Chapter End Notes

> Hordak would have been a terrible parent at that point in his life and he's self aware enough to know that. Still, I think having him acknowledge that would make sense for someone trying to be a better person.
>
> I also can't imagine him approving of how Shadow Weaver was treating the cadets. Not because he was even remotely a good person at that point, but because it wasn't efficient and wouldn't have been producing the best soldiers. As proven by at least half of Catra's fuck ups being caused by the issues she had thanks to worlds worst mother stand in.

A Well Earned Rest

Castle Crypto loomed above them in the dark, the image wavering in the downpour. Lonnie forced one foot in front of the other, determined that they would get there as soon as possible. Really they should have listened to the people in the village at the bottom of the mountain and stayed there for the night, but the castle was so close and she had just wanted to get travelling over and done with.

A glance to her right and she saw Kyle and Rogelio still trudging beside her, Imp strapped to Rogelio's front with a large clawed hand attempting to shield him from the worst of the rain while Kyle shivered with his arms wrapped around himself. God, she felt like Carta pushing them to carry on in this weather, but it was too late now. They were only a few minutes away.

Lightning struck the tower as they passed through the open gate of the outer wall. The village that sheltered within was deathly quiet. Either abandoned or too late and too wet for anyone to even consider so much as putting on a light.

"Where did the papers say we needed to report to?" Lonnie called over the storm, fighting the urge not to wrap her arms around herself the way Kyle was.

"Eastern tower," Kyle called back, his teeth chattering as he shivered.

They trudged through the unnervingly still settlement, the only sound and movement coming from the pouring rain, until they reached the door at the base of the tower. It was tucked out of the way, a slab of metal and probably some sort of servants entrance. A blank access pad was beside the door and, not seeing anything else that could open it, Lonnie tapped her finger against it.

The tower shielded them from the worst of the rain as they waited, the chill biting harder now they weren't moving. The seconds stretched on, lengthened by the cold and wet and the temptation to repeatedly jab at the access panel grew as they waited, even though it had already lit up in acknowledgement.

Finally the sound of a mechanism grinding to life rumbled out from the tower, the door groaned as it sank back, gears squealing in protest as it rolled sideways into the stone.

A shadow loomed out of the darkness. Glowing red eyes and gleaming teeth the only distinguishable features. Lonnie gasped and took a step back. Kyle let out a shriek and she stumbled over his sudden weight in her arms as Imp let out an unholy shriek.

The fabric of the baby carrier shredded as the demon baby ripped free and shot straight at the shadow. Rogelio snarled desperately trying to hold the little abomination back as Lonnie looked on in horror.

Until a light switch was flicked on inside the tower and Imp collided with their creator with a cooing trill, wrapping chubby little arms around Hordak's neck and rubbing their cheek against the shocked clone's jaw.

"Imp?" Hordak said, voice as stunned as it was soft as they placed a clawed hand on the demon baby's back. The little monster let out a happy squeak and scrambled around the back of Hordak's neck to take up their usual perch on his shoulder before going back to their cooing and face rubbing. "I'm glad you're safe," he said, reaching up to scratch at his chin before turning his attention to the three of them. Head tilted and ears flicking out, he took in their group as Lonnie set Kyle back on his feet and fought the urge to salute.

"Come in out of the rain," Hordak said, stepping aside to make space for them.

“Yes sir,” Lonnie replied on reflex, wincing as soon as it was out of her mouth but quickly getting into the tower regardless. Kyle and Rogelio were hot on her heels and soon the door was sliding shut behind them.

“Our papers said to report here for the next part of the clean up mission, sir,” Kyle said through chattering teeth. Hordak let out a long suffering sigh and Lonnie was sure he rolled his eyes, though it was pretty hard to tell with how they glowed.

“There’s no need for the “sir” anymore,” he grumbled as Lonnie finally wiped enough rain from her face to take a good look at him.

And her brain promptly broke. She couldn’t comprehend what she was seeing. It clashed so badly with past experience. This was beyond her ability to reconcile with reality.

He was wearing a silky indigo dressing gown that hung open, a white tank top, stripy pyjama bottoms and fluffy black slippers. Lord Hordak. The fearsome war lord. The man that had conquered half of Etheria. And he was wearing cosy loungewear. His hair was even the same sort of fluffy mess that Imp’s always was just after having washed it.

And just as her brain was rebooting, Lonnie realised that he had been examining them in turn with a displeased frown on his face.

“Follow me,” he said, the command in his voice every bit as undeniable as it had been in the Fright Zone.

She had to all but bite down on her tongue to stop herself from answering with “yes sir” as all three of them fell into line like it was second nature. He led them through what seemed like a maze to Lonnie. Twisting hallways and corridors that almost seemed designed to be confusing. Every now and again he turned slightly and instructed them “don’t step there,” or “ against the wall until we’re past the next painting,” or even “you’ll have to crouch under this sensor.”

Finally, they reached a small, seemingly normal, wooden door. Hordak opened it but didn't enter.

"The baths are through here," he said. "The bots will bring you some sleep wear and show you to the kitchen when you're finished." The three of them crossed the threshold, all of them utterly baffled and still Imp clung to Hordak and kept his happy trilling up. The door closed behind them and she could hear the muffled voice of Hordak as he talked to Imp.

"Woah," Kyle breathed out, pulling Lonnie's attention from the door to the rest of the room. It was huge. An extravagant tiled bathroom melding into a natural underground cavern. A claw foot tub, multiple huge shower stalls and in the more natural part of the room -cavern?- was a hot spring.

"So, how weird do you think this is going to be?" she asked. Rogelio gave a snarling growl followed by a shrug and hiss that was almost a raspberry before he quickly shed his sodden clothes to leap straight into the hot spring.

Well, that settled that she supposed. A shared glance with Kyle and a shrug later the pair of them joined Rogelio in the hot spring. After travelling through the freezing cold storm, the hot water felt like a blessing. It didn't take them long to clean up and get warm, but none of them were eager to leave the hot water.

A robot with far too many skinny pincer arms rolled into the room through a hidden door on a single wheel. The trio watched as it gathered up all of their sodden clothes and promptly rolled back to where it had come from.

"Huh, there were fewer deadly weapons on that than I'm used to seeing from one of Entrapta's bots," commented Kyle.

"They were probably just hidden," Lonnie pointed out. She doubted Entrapta had ever made anything that didn't at minimum explode.

A few short moments later and the robot returned with a stack of towels and a sets of clothing and slippers for the three of them, carrying the teetering pile with seemingly practised ease. Supplies carefully set down, the arms retracted and the bot seemingly deactivated by the door to the exit.

It was an effort not to fall asleep as the hot water soothed aching muscles and chased away the bone deep chill. While it wasn't the first time they had been able to relax, it had been a long trip after the hard work of helping with the rebuilding needed in Bright Moon. Lonnie didn't really feel the weight of guilt for working for the Horde the way a lot of others seemed to. What else were her options? She was born in the Horde, raised by the Horde, trained by the Horde with nothing else having a chance to creep in. But she still recognised that the Horde had grown from a tainted seed, that it had hurt people and done damage and that if you break something then you should fix it. So she had been pushing herself to fix the damage just as hard as she had been pushed to cause it.

It was Rogelio who prodded them into getting out of the hot water. The heat always had an energising effect on the lizard, making them more twitchy than relaxed. So out they got and into the provided lavender silk pyjamas they shimmied as the little bot sat still as a statue until they were in slippers and matching dressing gowns.

"This can't get any weirder," Lonnie said. "Right?"

"I don't think I've ever worn anything that feels like this," Kyle replied, rubbing his fingers over the soft slippery fabric in fascination. "I also don't think I've ever seen Entrapta in anything like this."

Lonnie and Rogelio shrugged, any further conversation by the bot reactivating and beeping enthusiastically. They followed it through the castle, never really sure what direction they were heading and sure they did at least one circle before they found themselves in a

kitchen far more rustic than any of them would expect from Crypto Castle.

It was large and well stocked, a table big enough for about eight people in the centre and Hordak at the oven watching over a bubbling pot while flipping a huge steak.

The three of them froze, the sight enough to break Lonnie's brain for what felt like the hundredth time that night. The sink was filled and almost overflowing with bubbles as a happy Imp chittered away, merrily splashing about as their creator stood cooking nearby.

"Take a seat," Lord Hordak ordered, gesturing over his shoulder with the tongs he had been using to turn the steak. "All three of you look like you need more adequate nutrition and rest so I've taken the liberty of putting a meal together for you before you retire."

"Er, thanks?" Kyle stuttered out, glancing to the other two for some sort of guidance and getting bewildered shrugs in return before they moved to do as they were told.

A moment of deeply awkward silence later and Hordak was serving each of them a meal. The steak for Rogelio and a bowl of thick vegetable filled stew with fresh bread for Lonnie and Kyle. The oddest part by far was that the former leader of the Etherian Horde had seemingly taken one look at their group and realised that they would have different dietary requirements. Discovering that Rogelio was an obligate and near exclusive carnivore once the bars had ran out had been seriously unpleasant.

Rogelio growled out what Lonnie assumed were thanks, breaking the awkwardness before the three of them dug in.

"Thank you sir," Kyle said between mouthfuls. "This is really good!"

"You're welcome, but please don't call me sir," Hordak reminded them as he went back to the sink to give a delighted Imp a

scratch under the chin.

“Time to get you out of there before you turn into a prune,” he carried on, reaching out to take hold of Imp. The little trouble marker nimbly dodged, dunking back into the water only to pop back out into the bubbles and squirt water into Hordak's face. Lonnie froze, ready to leap to save the little miscreant from Hordak’s temper.

Except she didn’t need to. Sputtering a little, Hordak wiped the water from his eyes as Imp let out that chittering screech that she had come to recognise as their laugh.

“Come here trouble,” Hordak growl out, plunging his hands into the bubbles to grab the little terror and pulled them out. Imp whipped his and flapped his wings to spray as much water over his creator as possible before he was bundled into a fluffy towel.

“Still a menace, I see,” Hordak said fondly as he cradled the creature with one arm to rub the towel against their hair with the other.

“*Still a menace*,” they repeated with an open mouthed grin before settling into that quiet cooing trill that Lonnie thought of as a purr.

A comfortable quiet settled over the kitchen as they ate and Hordak got Imp dry. The food was good and the chance to just rest a while was better, but Lonnie couldn’t stop herself from glancing to Hordak and Imp.

They weren’t anything like what she had thought they would be. Their time with the strange creature had made them realise that he wasn’t a bot, wasn’t a creepy little pet. He was more like a strangely feral child. At once frightfully independent and helpless. From a distance Hordak seemed to treat him like a well trained dog, not close up Lonnie could easily see that that wasn’t the case.

This fussing, teasing and tousling. It was something else. Something that she wasn’t sure she could name. It looked almost

familiar and filled her with a strange sort of nostalgia for something she had never had. It carried on as Imp was finally dry and forced into clearly custom made pyjamas that accommodated his wings and tail. She half expected Hordak to shoo him off but instead he kept him close, not just perching on his shoulder, but held against him as the claws of his free hand stroked through Imp's damp hair. They even smiled as Imp gave a near silent yawn and nuzzled in closer, closing his eyes.

A warmth that had nothing to do with the stew settled in Lonnie. Imp was annoying. He was a brat, he rushed into dangerous places without a thought, repeated exactly what you didn't want him to and stole the best bit of whatever you were eating. There had been times where no matter how vulnerable he could be Lonnie had been half tempted to drop him off a cliff and hope he forgot he could fly. But now? Now she was sure that bringing the little terror with them, feeding him, protecting him when they could and getting him out of trouble when they couldn't, had absolutely been the right thing to do.

A moment or two later and soft snuffly snores were rising up from Hordak's shoulder and Lonnie felt her face heat as she realised her former boss was watching her watch them.

"Thank you," he said before it could get awkward.

"I er, what for?"

"For keeping him safe," Hordak explained. "For bringing him here. I hadn't let myself think about him. I was so sure that he was, well, that I'd never find him again. So thank you. I know he can be difficult and I'm sure he hasn't made it easy for you."

"You can say that again," Kyle mumbled. Rogelio growled and kicked him under the table, but Hordak's smile only widened a little, showing the edge of a glowing red fang.

"I made him, I know what he can be like. He likes his mischief and if you don't find him an outlet for it he'll find one himself."

"That sounds about right," Lonnie said as Hordak's words rang in her ears.

He made him. *He made him*. Of course he had been fussing! Of course he had been affectionate. He wasn't some pet owner, he was a *parent*.

"He likes you as well. Called you his brothers."

"He did?" Lonnie asked, wondering how he had gotten that point across.

"He did," Hordak confirmed. "I admit that my grasp of the concept of family is somewhat shaky, but as far as I'm concerned that's close enough for me. Consider yourselves welcome here at any time. Now if you'll excuse me, I should get this one to bed. A bot will show you to your rooms, or room? Are the three of you together or would you rather be separated for the night?"

Rogelio gave a hissing growl in response.

"As you wish. I'll inform the bots. Make sure you finish your meals, all three of you look like you require adequate nutrition. Goodnight."

"Goodnight," Lonnie and Kyle echoed back, both equally baffled by what had just happened as Hordak left the room with Imp still snoozing against his shoulder like any baby would in their parents arms."

"Did we just get adopted by Hordak?" Lonnie asked, wondering what the hell had just happened.

"I really have no idea, but it kind of sounded like it," Kyle replied. At least he sounded just as confused as she felt.

"I sure am glad this didn't get any weirder," she said sarcastically before taking another spoonful of stew. "Well, if we did just get adopted, at least it was by someone that can cook."

The Talk™

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Kardroh lingered by the door to the courtyard, caught between wanting to help and not wanting to get in the way of the hustle and bustle. Hordak was out there, conducting robots like a symphony in preparation for the excursion to Beast Island. Etherians of many different species worked diligently, loading transports, packing crates, strapping down equipment, and his brother checked it all. Assigning work, directing loads and vehicles and generally acting as hub of the activity.

Activity that was both bizarre and comforting to see. There was no hive mind at play, but Kardoh would recognise the Horde at work anywhere. Except this wasn't the Horde, at least not as he had ever seen it before. Everyone was different. Different heights, different races, colouring, hair or lack of. No two people wore the same thing yet they moved as a collective. Seamless efficiency and a single will directing them. True that will was acting through speech and hand signal rather than neural link, yet it was so familiar in its unfamiliarity.

Was this simply what happened when people were used to working as a unit? Was it something to do with upbringing or training?

And then came chaos.

Entrapta flung herself through the fray of the work. Sort of helping, but mostly fussing. And even with the introduction of this whirlwind the work carried on with ease. Flowing around her without any real effort as if they were more than used to the Princess bouncing from place to place and swinging around on her hair with nephew Imp shrieking in joy as he swooped in her wake.

The only person truly distracted by her was Hordak himself. He did a good job of working on despite tracking her every movement, never giving her less than half of his attention as he continued to tap away on the tablet in his hand and answer questions, but Kardoh knew what to look for. Knew how his brother immediately went soft around the edges whenever Entrapta was around, always reaching for her in ways he likely didn't even realise.

Kadroh had always thought of himself and his brothers as replaceable or interchangeable, it took seeing Hordak with Entrapta to fully realise that that wasn't true. In as many ways as they were identical, with all the love he felt for the Princess that had freed him and then helped him see that Prime's light was blinding rather than illuminating, he could never be Hordak for her. He would never know exactly what to say to make her smile the way his brother did, would never flush when her hair curled around him, would never look at her with more worship in his eyes than he had ever looked to Prime with.

He watched as Entrapta launched herself from the top of one of the huge transporters right into Hordak. Stoic Hordak who barely reacted as Entrapta wrapped him in her arms and hair to press a firm kiss against his mouth before springing away to do something else. Hordak swayed ever so slightly in her direction as she left, an instinctive movement showing how deeply he was drawn to

her. His face was slack and his eyes as empty as when he had stepped out of the purification pool, except there was a touch of disbelieving contentment to the way his gaze tracked Entrapta. A strange whistle erupted from the workers, quickly followed by a wave of laughter and Hordak shaking himself out of his revere. His ears were still pink along the top as he half heartedly scowled at his people before calling out to enforce a rest period.

The Horde being told to rest by their Prime, how very bizarre. But also useful. It meant he didn't need to interrupt.

Kadroh made his way through the people that were downing tools and setting equipment down, smiling at all the new faces he didn't recognise. Entrapta ignored the call, as she often did, but then she wasn't of the Horde the way these other beings seemed to be and likely felt no need to obey. Hordak however had set himself down on the nearest stable surface of suitable height. While the others seemed to be on the hunt for sustenance, Hordak seemed happy just to sit.

"Brother Hordak!" he said brightly, not able to keep the tremble of his nerves out of his voice. It was strange to compare how easy ignoring his emotions had once been. He had been numb to them, perhaps because of the hive mind, but now? Now he felt like was going to burst with them. Powerless to hold them in, even if he wanted to and thankful that he rarely did.

"Kadroh," his brother replied with a nod. "Is something wrong?"

“No! No, why would something be wrong? Everything is wonderful and I am not at all facing down an overwhelming quantity of self doubt and highly specific social anxiety.” Why did he always do that? Hordak levelled him with an unimpressed look as Kadroh tried to smile and clicked his claws together out of nerves.

“If ever I doubted that Bow and Adora were both very influential on you in the early days of your disconnecting, the way you ramble when overly emotional would be enough to convince me,” he drawled before letting out a sigh. “What is it?”

Kadroh looked down to his hands, still tapping his claws against each other and wishing that he had put more thought into what he was going to say than his panic about getting in the way.

“You and Entrapta, I mean, the two of you- I- er.” His brother flicked an ear and raised an eyebrow at him. “How did you two, er, I mean, how did you know-”

“Kadroh,” Hordak interrupted, the same look on his face as when he was studying something he considered peculiar. “Is there someone that you have a romantic interest in?”

Kadroh’s face heated, his ears burned and stuck out to the sides without his permission. Embarrassment was new and unpleasantly stomach churning.

“Erm. I think so? She’s wonderful. Kind, artistic. So skilled. And when I look at her my heart beats uncomfortably fast but I feel like I can’t look away because her hair catches the light in the kitchen like an emerald and her eyes are so blue and you’re looking at me in a very strange way brother.”

“I apologise, but this is somewhat amusing to observe from the outside for a change.” Hordak tilted his head and studied him with a lopsided smile that exposed a fang. “Green hair, blue eyes and in the kitchen. Baker, I take it?”

“Yes,” he admitted, not sure why his brother knowing exactly who he was talking about felt so much more embarrassing. “I just, I know that I think she’s marvellous, but I don’t know what to do with that. And you have Entrapta so I thought, perhaps, you might know?”

“For a start, don’t compare the two of you to Entrapta and myself. Our circumstances were very different. As for Baker, ask them to spend time with you. Interpersonal relationships seem to require repeated periods of extended interaction. A joint activity or experience enjoyed by both of you would be the preference.”

“Huh?”

“Etherians call it a “date” when there is a romantic intention,” Hordak clarified, the slightest sneer letting Kadroh know exactly what he thought of that word. He didn’t pay any mind to it, over the last few months he had learnt that Hordak had dozens upon

dozens of petty grievances with pretty much everything. It was practically a hobby as far as Kadroh could tell.

"And did you take Entrapta on a "date" to disclose your interest to her?"

"No. She travelled the galaxy to find me and I killed my god for her," he said, his voice matter of fact but his smile small and fond.

"Oh."

"As I said, do not compare yourself to Entrapta and I. We are not the norm. In a truly astonishing number of ways." Hordak paused, tapping his chin with a single claw in consideration before a different type of smile spread across his face. Similar to the single fanged smile from earlier but somehow different. Darker. The red of their teeth glowed brighter and for perhaps the first time he saw why so many people had been afraid of his brother.

"If you really want to know about such things, you should speak with Bow. Entrapta and I are going to be absent for at least four months and I imagine that you'll have many, *many,* questions about Etherian mating rituals. As an Etherian with a special interest in interpersonal relationships, he is best placed to answer them."

"You really think so?" Kadroh asked, clicking his claws again and feeling oddly like he was in some sort of trap.

“Oh absolutely,” Hordak replied, his smile spreading to show both sets of fangs. “No matter how awkward you think the question is, I am certain that Bow would not only be able to answer it for you but he would be happy to.”

It made sense. Bow was not only Etherian but also the same species as Baker. They had also pair bonded to another Etherian and so clearly had some measure of knowledge about how such things worked here. He was also clearly knowledgeable and well educated and had made a point of assuring Kadroh that they would support their new life on this planet.

“Thank you brother,” he said, relief flowing through him at a resolution finally being in sight even if he did have the strangest feeling that his brother was up to something. Still, that strange tactile urge bubbled up in him. “May I hug you?” he asked.

“I suppose so,” Hordak said with a sigh and a put upon expression that Kadroh had learnt was simply him complaining as a hobby again. He bore it well when Kadroh wrapped his arms around him, even returning the hug for a brief moment. He made a point of not embracing him for too long. Unlike many of the other clones, his brother was not particularly tactile unless Entrapta or Imp were involved.

The Princess drew their attention as they parted, landing on top of one of the transporters with a loud thump as her hair reached up to start making adjustments to the nearby small crane.

“This is gonna be the best holiday ever!” she cried out with glee as Hordak watched her with a smile. The love poured out of his brother as it always did when the Princess was around and Kadroh’s heart swelled with joy for them. If one of them could find a love like this, then there was hope for all of his brothers that wanted it.

Perhaps Bow would help in putting together an info pack for all the clones?

Chapter End Notes

Look, he's come a long way, but he still gets those little evil urges okay?

Next chapter, a long overdue conversation with Catra.

Malignant Ghosts

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was good that she was here. All she did was hurt people, whether she meant to or not. All the scars her claws had left on the people she loved, all the hearts burned and broken by her lashing out. It was good that she was here. Would be better if she never left. One foot in front of the other. It wouldn't take much. Just follow the ringing in her ears and she would never put another scar on Adora, never swipe at someone she loved with sharp claws and sharper tongue because of her own bruised and battered heart.

All she needed to do to keep everyone safe from herself was walk off the beach and into the forest. So simple. She took a step. Then another. The hazy buzz of someone calling her name reached her as she took her third step. Easy. Simple. Adora would never need to flinch awake from a nightmare she had caused again.

A hand clamped around her upper arm, the pin prick of claws digging in. She paid it no mind, ignored the noise of words and tried to take another step.

A yank, vicious and ripping and Catra blinked aware hurtling through the air. Too late to compensate even with her reflexes, she came down hard on her shoulder. The ground swayed when she hit it, the wood biting through her fur to her skin. Blinking and a little dazed, Catra stared at the wood and tried to put the pieces together. Then her world shook with a familiar growl and a series

of splashes. A boat. She was on a boat. A row boat that was being pushed from the shore by Hordak of all people.

Blinking and baffled, Catra forced herself to sit rather than sprawl as her former commander jumped from the water into the boat and took up the oars without comment, rowing with glowing red teeth gritted. The haze in her mind lifted with each snarling pull against the sea and she realised that he wasn't wearing his armour. Was instead wearing a white tank top and blue and white striped pyjama bottoms. The dark of night and the soft moonlight registering before she could fully comprehend that this was Hordak ready for bed, baring his teeth at the exertion of getting her away from Beast Island.

She should take over. He was so thin. The muscle on his chest and arms wasted away to the point that she would have thought it useless if she hadn't just been thrown ten feet as if she was as light as a feather. But even with that there was the rest of his condition to consider. The random pains and passing out. She should take over. Should row them back to shore.

She didn't. Instead she just stared, almost uncomprehending.

Hordak glanced behind him, a little frown of consideration on his face as he clearly tried to run the numbers on their distance from the island. Seemingly satisfied, he set the oars to their resting positions and slumped a little on the bench.

It was odd, but even with his glowing eyes that lacked a pupil, Catra could tell that he was glancing over her body, checking for

any sign of injury, lingering on the already scabbed over scratches that he had left on her arm.

"Are you alright Catra?"

The words registered but felt foreign, like a language she didn't know but somehow understood the meaning of. A fine tremble started in her hand. A tremor that she was aware of but could only distantly feel. It spread rapidly to the rest of her, like building pressure. Higher and higher until, painfully, it burst.

A broken sob forced its way out and she threw herself into Hordak's arms, clinging to the bony man for all she was worth. He froze for a moment as she cried into his chest but soon relaxed to wrap one of his arms around her and run his claws carefully through her hair. He was warm. She hadn't expected that. With how thin he was, he looked like he should be cold all the time, but he seemed to burn against her as she cried into his chest.

The sobs that wracked her body came up like broken glass, sharp and painful enough that she was surprised there was no blood. She shook and cried like she had never allowed herself to do before, not even as a child. Especially not as a child. And through it all, Hordak held her. His claws soothing their way through her hair. With his slim build and light touch she could almost imagine someone else in his place. A ghost with sharp nails and nothing soft but that had been the closest thing to a mother Catra had ever known.

The very idea of it ushered in a new wave of agony, rushing through her to pour out with the flood of tears. She couldn't stop it. Couldn't fight it anymore than she could fight the tide no matter how much she wanted to. Self control shattering and leaving her surrounded by debris just like it had when she had trashed the command room.

"I miss her," he stuttered out, the words forced out between deep wrenching sobs that barely left the space for breath never mind coherent words. "Why do I miss her?"

Hordak made a strange little chirrup and held her tighter, riding out the storm with her. And a storm was what it was. Devastating, powerful but ultimately blowing itself out into little more than exhausted silence.

She should have felt humiliated, embarrassed or disgusted. Something should have had her flinging herself away from Hordak's hold on her and denying what had just happened. But she didn't. Instead she felt strangely clean, perhaps a little numb as she stayed in his arms and steadily regained control of her breathing and her senses.

"Are you alright, Catra?" he asked, still petting her hair and his voice a deep and peaceful rumble.

"Yeah," she mumbled, finally shifting away from him and oh, there was the embarrassment. "Yeah, I'm fine. It won't happen again. I'll be ready to get back on it tomorrow," she assured him, looking out to sea and wishing she could be anywhere else.

“The only thing you’re getting on tomorrow is the transport to the mainland,” Hordak said, firm but also somehow gentle. It was unmistakably an order but she could hear the compassion in his voice. Panic struck. She couldn’t be thrown away, Not now. Not again!

“I’m not useless,” she snapped, eyes sharp and fangs exposed. “I can still work-”

“I know,” he interrupted. “But you need rest. The island got to you and you need to go home to Adora and remember who you are and why the world is better with you in it. Then you can come back here and carry on helping.”

Her ears drooped, the snarl falling from her lips and the hiss dying in her throat.

“I’m not discarding you,” he insisted, cutting to the core of what had spooked her. “What you do here is valuable but your life, your wellbeing, is more important than what you can do for other people.”

She looked away from him again, leaning against the side of the boat as she stared up at the still unfamiliar stars. Hordak followed her lead, not pushing but simply there, a calming presence on a calm sea. Hordak. A calming presence. What had Etheria come to?

“This place,” she said, pulling her knees up to wrap her arms and tail around them. “The way it gets in your head, makes you doubt yourself and doubt what anyone could see in you. It reminds me of her. I swear it talks with her voice sometimes.” Why she was saying this to him, Catra had no idea, she just knew that she couldn’t say it to Adora.

“Shadow Weaver?” he asked, though she could tell he’d already known the answer. She nodded. Still not looking at him.

“There were a couple of years that the other cadets were jealous of Adora and me. None of them had anything close to a parent and there was Shadow Weaver. Taking a personal interest in the two of us. After a while, they stopped being jealous because they saw we had a kind of mother and started feeling sorry for us. They saw what she was like, that nothing was ever good enough and how she would deal with failure and they just knew that they were better off. Even with Adora. She never hurt Adora the way she did me, was never as cruel to her as she was to me, but she used me to keep her in line. I was something to threaten, something to take away.

“She was *awful* to us. The constant gaslighting, manipulation, trying to set us against each other and dangling the possibility of some real affection just close enough to convince me that I might be able to reach it but always pulling it away at the last moment.” She scrubbed a hand across her face, refusing to shed another tear, though she wasn’t sure she even had any left. She felt raw and bloody, painfully exposed but gods it was almost a relief.

“And then, as if she wanted to make sure that neither of us could ever keep hating her, no matter how much she deserved it, no matter how much she had put us through, she wanted to force us to feel grateful to her for the rest of our lives. So she saved us by getting herself killed and that wasn’t even the worst part.

“She said “you’re welcome.” When she died. Did her stupid self sacrifice thing. She said “you’re welcome.””

Hordak stared at her. The silence building as he blinked, his jaw set and expression going cold in a way she hadn’t seen since before Prime had taken them. She watched, stomach tightening, as he took a deep breath and clearly mentally counted to ten. His right eye twitched. He took another breath, grinding his teeth as he mentally counted again. She could practically see the numbers tick over behind his eyes.

He got to six.

“That *rotten bitch* ,” he snarled. “After what she put you through, *that* was her goodbye? She could have said she loved you, that she was proud of you or for the first time in her wretched life she could have just kept her *fucking* mouth shut.”

Catra gaped at him. Had he really just- was she hearing things?

“I apologise for losing my temper, I realise that it could be triggering for you, but if I could bring that vicious hag back to life

again I *would* , just so I could gut her with my bare hands. *You're welcome.* What the fuck was wrong with her?"

A laugh bubbled out of her, startling her as much as it did Hordak. Much like the tears, it was uncontrollable and left her prone, except this time she felt light and free from it.

"Is this positive laughter or hysterical laughter?" Hordak asked, his voice edging close to panic and his ears pitched back. "I've only ever heard you laugh to mock people before. I really can't tell if this is a good laugh or a worrying one."

"It's a good one," she wheezed, gripping her own sides as she struggled to get a hold of herself. "It's just- *you're angry* ."

"Of course I'm angry, she was *awful* to you."

"But you're angry *for me* . Not at me, for me. You've kept a lid on your temper for nearly a year and *this* is what makes you blow your top? It's just- it's funny."

His anger dissipated into confusion, his head tilted and his ears at an uneven angle. As she looked at him, taking in his concern and uncertainty, her laughter fading into a smile, she felt somehow cleansed. Still raw and bloody, but clean.

“Like it or not, I have a sense of responsibility to anyone left from my Horde.”

“I wasn’t your responsibility,” she said, too worn out to snarl like she would have any other time.

“You were *all* my responsibility and I failed you all. You more than most. And more personally than most.”

“Well, I did lie to you,” she replied, a strange squirming discomfort beginning to gnaw in her stomach. “Multiple times. And there was the Entrapta thing.” Shame. It was probably shame. It was usually shame when she thought about that frantic time between returning from the Crimson Waste and the arrival of Prime.

“Which she has forgiven you for, and while I can’t pretend I’m thrilled it happened I understand your motives much better now than I did then.”

“I’m glad someone does,” Catra muttered, turning her face away. A large clawed hand settled on her shoulder, gentle but a firm presence. She turned her eyes back to Hordak, ears drooping and tiredness seeping into her very bones.

“Fear is a powerful and irrational motivator and I hardly gave you reason to not be afraid,” he said, his voice low and soft, genuinely contrite in a way that would have seemed forced before his outburst over Shadow Weaver’s last words. “Your position was

seemingly fragile, you had had multiple traumatic instances of being passed over or left behind and there I was disregarding your competence at nearly every turn and threatening to kill you multiple times. You did what you felt you needed to ensure your survival."

"You got that from Perfuma, didn't you?" she teased, hoping to kill the direction of the conversation. Rehabilitation or not, she was so not ready to begin unpacking that basket of misery.

"Actually I got that from reading multiple psychology books," he replied with a small smirk, taking his hand from her shoulder.

"Planning on giving therapy sessions once we're done here?"

"Oh definitely. Everyone should come to the creepy castle in the cliffs and talk about their feelings with the scary red eyed monster that lives there and likely caused a significant amount of their issues. I'm sure that would be incredibly therapeutic."

Catra gave a little huff of a laugh. Hordak could be sarcastic, who knew? She was pretty sure he rolled his eyes as well, but it was difficult to tell with him. Though the idea of talking through he issues with someone like him, someone that could understand and wouldn't baulk at the gory details had a sort of appeal that the group sessions with Perfuma never would. Perhaps it would be something to think about after their probation was over.

She was about to bite something back, something that was obviously going to be very witty, but it got cut off by a yawn.

“Try and get some sleep, Catra,” Hordak said. “We’ll head back to shore when it gets light. It’s always easier to deal with the signal in daylight.”

“What about you?” she asked with a frown.

“I don’t need much sleep, I’ll be fine,” he assured her. She nodded, accepting the answer much more easily than she should from someone that she knew to have a serious illness. Then again, he didn’t need to breathe so what did she know?

“Hordak?” she said, trying not to sound unsure or timid and not entirely sure she pulled it off.

“Yes Catra?”

“Could you- this is so dumb. I should even be asking. Could you stroke my hair again? Like you were doing earlier.” She had no idea why she asked that, she had no right, especially not after what they had put each other through.

There was ridicule, no anger. Just as close to a soft smile as Hordak could manage when he wasn’t looking directly at Entrapta and an open arm. There was a fleeting moment, a single second of hesitation, then Catra was curled back against him being held like a child with sharp claws gently petting at her.

She only realised she was purring in the moment she slipped into sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry about the wait for this. Just once more chapter and it's done.

Guardian Angel

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Why were feelings so damn exhausting? Feelings that weren't even his. Wrung out and aching in every muscle, Hordak did his best to hold himself tall as he strode back to the tent he shared with Entrapta. Old instinct telling him to hide any sign of weakness even though he knew it was no longer necessary. Knew it well enough that he was comfortable walking through camp with his arms exposed.

He could hear activity in the tent even before he pushed the flap aside to enter. The quiet sparking fizzle that meant Entrapta was working on something was like a comforting song to him and it warmed his weary heart once he was inside and could see her bent over the complex looking circuitry. Mask down, sitting cross legged on her hair as she tinkered.

Hordak couldn't help but admire her as she worked, a soft smile sneaking its way onto his face. The flask of her electric soldering iron lit her up in brief sparks, the angle making it seem like she glowed from within. Truly, she was as beautiful as she was brilliant.

And then he ruined it by yawning.

The spark stopped as Entrapta flicked up her mask and turned her hair so she faced him. An overjoyed grin spread across her face

and Hordak sighed with happy relief at the sight. He still didn't fully understand the effect that this wondrous woman had on him and had long since given up on attempting to intellectualise it in favour of simply experiencing it.

He also didn't understand why her smile vanished until he was suddenly much closer to the floor and wrapped in purple hair.

Ah. He'd pushed himself too much again.

"Apologies," he managed to mumble as Entrapta both lifted him back to his feet and pulled herself closer. "I hadn't realised I was so far gone."

"That's okay," she replied gently, keeping herself off the ground to be at eye level with him even as a portion of her locks support him in staying upright. "You didn't sleep at all last night, did you?" She asked with not an ounce of judgement in her voice.

The hold was firm, but not too restrictive. If he really wanted to move, he would be able to. And he really did want to, though not too far. Hordak allowed himself to wilt forward, his head landing on Entrapta's shoulder. She took his extremely unsubtle hint and wrapped him in her arms as well as her hair, holding him close and stroking one of his ears in a flawlessly slow and rhythmic speed that he knew was as much about providing him comfort as it was her stimming.

“The signal got to Catra,” he said by way of explanation. “I spent the night out in a rowboat to keep her safe. I also may have had another one of those moments people keep making fun of me for.”

“You were parental to Catra? I don’t see any bleeding though.”

He snorted against her shoulder, too tired to really laugh but amused all the same.

“I actually believe it went rather well. I managed to order her to depart on a boat to the mainland without her feeling as though she was being thrown away or useless. She even asked me to hold her and stroke her hair.”

“Can’t blame her there, you’re really gentle with your claws and it feels supper relaxing,” she mused.

He lifted a hand to run his claws through her hair only for a lock of it to catch his wrist and prevent the motion. He huffed a little in protest, he liked stroking Entrapta’s hair. It was almost as soothing for him as it apparently was for her.

“Hordak, you’re exhausted,” she chided softly. “The only reason you’re as upright as you are is because I’m holding you. As much as I really enjoy when you stroke my hair, you need to sleep. Come on. Let’s get you to bed.”

He gave her neck a little nip, more simply to be a brat than out of any real intent. She gave a surprise squeak at the action then batted at his arm as she pulled back with an adorable frown.

"To *sleep,* Hordak. Sleep," she chastised even as her cheeks turned red.

"I was merely joking," he assured her, admiring her blush. "As much as my desire and adoration of you never tires, my body, unfortunately, does."

Her blush deepened and she blessed him with a coy smile before shaking her head at him and beginning to guide him towards the narrow cot that passed for a bed in this place. By the stars he was looking forward to being back at Crypto Castle and back in their own bed where there was plenty of room for the pair of them, even if they were being more active than merely sleeping.

He allowed Entrapta more or less settle him in, something that had once embarrassed him but that now he found he rather enjoyed. His eyelids felt heavier with every passing moment and he knew sleep would come easily to him for a change.

"Cartra-"

"Will be on the ship," Entrapta assured him before placing a kiss on his cheek.

“And breaks-”

“Will be regular and enforced,” she said before giving the lightest of kisses on his lips. “Sleep, Hordak. You rest up here and I’ll make sure that no one out there pushes themselves too hard or forgets to eat. Let me do the worrying for you for today.”

And with that final meagre weight lifted from him, Hordak allowed sweet dreamless sleep to claim him, safe in the knowledge that Entrapta was watching over him and his duties until he was strong enough once again to shoulder the burden.

Chapter End Notes

Finally finished. No idea why this last chapter took me so long but hopefully you've all enjoyed it.

End Notes

Hope you enjoyed my nonsense. Next chapter will be up as soon as it's done, which will probably be pretty soon. I don't know why, but this fandom is eating my brain.

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